

mostly came from the intermediary or upper castes. We have been left without land to cultivate and be permanent serfs of others," said K.K. Koch, a prominent Dalit intellectual. According to him, the Dalits and tribals form the majority of the state's landless and deprived. The Naxalite movement of the '70s had petered out in Kerala soon due to the absence of major inequalities in the society because of the collapse of the feudal relations on account of land reforms and also the hegemony of the "Left" space by the traditional communist parties. Consequently, the state, despite its Left tradition, still remained outside the Red Corridor of Left extremism spreading across the country. The Dalit and tribals, however, today stand out as a sore thumb in the much lauded 'Kerala Model' and hence offer fertile ground for extremist politics to take root.

The Dalits point out that even the Left is driven by its upper-caste leadership's value systems and worldview. Critics like Kancha Ilaiah have said the communist parties, too, were led from the beginning by members of Brahmin landlord families. They maintain that though the Left's

**DALIT HUMAN RIGHTS MOVEMENT
ACTIVISTS PROTESTING
AGAINST DISCRIMINATION**



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CLASS DIVIDE IN KERALA POLLS (in per cent)

	LDF		UDF	
	2004	2009	2004	2009
Rich	38	28	41	63
Middle	35	35	50	51
Lower Middle	52	47	34	35
Poor	48	48	38	39
Very Poor	52	57	33	31

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Brahmin leadership has given way to intermediate castes now, there is no Dalit representation worth the name. "Has the CPI(M) ever had an SC or ST member in their Politburo?" asks a Dalit leader. The Kerala CPI(M) organisation has 3.36 lakh members (CPI-M's largest state unit) and among them 14.98 per cent is the Scheduled Caste and Scheduled Tribes population which forms 0.9 per cent of the wing.

The 2009 Lok Sabha election was a watershed in the relation between the Dalits and Left parties. Almost every Dalit organisation in the state, including the traditionally CPI-led Kerala Pulaya Maha Sabha (KPMS)—organisation of the lowest Dalit caste—openly opposed the LDF and supported the UDF. "More than the support to the UDF, it was a gesture to the LDF to not take us for granted anymore," said Punnala Sreekumar, KPMS's general secretary. This forced the CPI to ask its leader and the KPMS's state President T.V. Babu to quit panchayat presidentship for having worked against party candidates. The KPMS even campaigned against a CPI candidate who was the son of the late

P.K. Raghavan, its founder president and CPI veteran. The CPI(M), realising its losing support among the SC and STs, has now begun special programmes to stem the tide. Among them was the party's first-ever exclusive SC and ST conference held in Kochi last year.

The new Dalit and tribal organisations in Kerala, too, are increasingly resorting to violent ways to express themselves. The latest was the killing of two non-Dalits in Varkala near Thiruvananthapuram, allegedly by a new militant Dalit organisation called Dalit Human Rights Movement (DHRM) founded in 2007, whose workers travel on motorcycles and wear black T-shirts with Ambedkar's pictures. The new militant political alliance called DHM (Dalit-Human rights groups-Islamists-Maoists) shaping up across the country has also begun active operation in the state. T.K. Chandrachoodan, general secretary of the RSP, said, "The new Dalit groups' growth is a sign of the Left's failure to address their problems." Or the first sign of marxist mortality. ■